

LET'S SHOP!

What if a bot could be your go-to shopping partner?

ARNAB MUKHERJEE

arnab@digit.in

First day in a new city, you're there to attend a party. After a styling session that you booked earlier using the chatbot for the best salon in town, you walk into a clothing retail store to get yourself some new threads for a party. There's no-one there except you and a couple of other customers. The moment you enter, you are identified, you've already specified what you need to one of the innumerable chat kiosks and a convenient in-store navigation screen pops up on your smartphone to guide you to the partywear section. The mechanized gallery highlights the ones that will suit you the best, according to size and past preferences, and once you make a choice, it suggests a couple of other outfits and accessories for you to try on as well. Once you've decided, you walk out wearing your new outfit. You have a self-driven cab ready and waiting, and on the way your digital assistant suggests that you get some flowers or wine for the occasion. You agree and ask for the flowers and wine to be delivered to you at the venue itself. They're waiting for you when your cab pulls up to the address.

This isn't sci-fi or the future; the technology to do this already exists.

You could literally do half of this right now if you walked into the Amazon Go store in Seattle, Washington (which is not open to the public yet), and get a ride on one of the many driverless vehicles being tested. AI and online shopping are already inseparable. When was the last time when you saw a completely suggestion-free shopping experience online? According to Gartner, by 2020, 85 per cent of customer interactions will be managed without humans. And it's predicted that by 2018, AI technology will advance to the point where service bots can recognise the voices and faces of customers.

ALL THAT CHATTER

While AI and robotics still have a long way to go, chatbots are pretty advanced right now. Talking to a bot is not new, but the improved chat AI has made this a customer service necessity! It's why so many sites have chat options in their service menus. Chat is also the preferred way of interacting with real customer service people as well. Haptik is a platform that offers this, but have shifted to a 'human augmented intelligence' model recently.

While dedicated services such as Haptik are doing it independently, it is startups like Niki.ai and Talespin who are truly bringing chat to you by implementing it for any service. While Niki.ai also has a mobile app similar

to Haptik, it also has a chatbot SDK. Explaining the direction in which the platform is headed, Sachin Jaiswal, Co-Founder, Niki.ai, says "In the very near future, Niki will also 'learn' about the user so that the recommendations are much more accurate. For example, if you frequently travel on Fridays and by night buses, just a 'show me some buses to Mumbai' will get you responses tailored to your needs."

WHY DOES IT WORK?

The growing popularity of chatbots might have a couple of local factors behind it. We all seek shopping tips



TELL US WHAT YOU THINK

Take our reader survey and win prizes!

Go to:
<http://digit.in/dsurvey17>